Phase 0 · Production document

Controls and Interface

Input bindings, the diegetic satchel and sketchbook, how the game communicates without a HUD, menus, settings, accessibility and browser behaviour.

Applies to	All episodes · features marked with the episode that introduces them
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01 Interface Goals

Goal	Meaning
Diegetic first	Information lives on objects Sora holds or sees: the lamp's gauge, the sketchbook, the matchbox. No health bar, minimap, crosshair or objective marker.
Few, honest exceptions	Subtitles, a save indicator, first-time control hints and accessibility options are allowed on screen (section 6.3).
Simple controls	Every action has one key. New actions arrive one per episode, never several at once.
Tension stays on	Opening the satchel or sketchbook does not pause the game (an accessibility option can change this).
Readable in two languages	All interface text in English and Khmer, using Ubuntu and Preah Vihear.

02 Controls

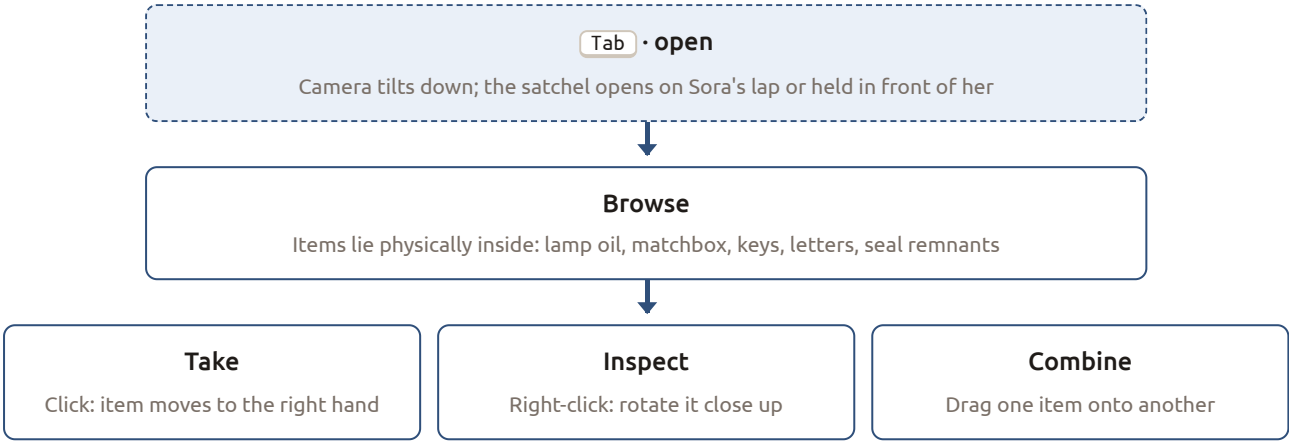
Action	Keyboard and mouse	Gamepad	From	Notes
Move	`W` `A` `S` `D`	Left stick	Ep 1	Walking pace by default
Look	Mouse	Right stick	Ep 1	
Hurry	Hold `Shift`	Click left stick	Ep 1	Faster but much louder; drains no stamina
Crouch	`C` or `Ctrl`	Click right stick	Ep 1	Toggle or hold (setting). Crawling happens automatically in tight spaces
Interact / pick up	`E`	A / Cross	Ep 1	Hold for continuous actions (turning a dial)
Use held item	Left mouse	RT / R2	Ep 1	Strike match, pour, throw
Raise / aim item	Right mouse	LT / L2	Ep 1	Raise the lamp to read its gauge; aim a throw; hold up the compass (Ep 4)
Lamp on / off	`F`	X / Square	Ep 1	Relighting costs a match
Lamp shutter	`R`	LB / L1	Ep 2	Hides the light instantly; flame keeps burning
Hold breath	Hold `Space`	Hold RB / R1	Ep 2	About 6 s; releasing late causes a loud gasp
Satchel	`Tab`	Y / Triangle	Ep 1	Inventory, combining, choosing the held item
Sketchbook	`Q`	D-pad up	Ep 1	Opens at the newest entry
Row (boat)	`A` / `D` strokes, `W` both	LT / RT	Ep 3	Left and right oars
Pause	`Esc`	Start / Options	Ep 1	Cannot be rebound (section 10)

Every binding except `Esc` can be changed in settings. The lamp is always in Sora's left hand; the right hand holds the selected item.

03 Hands and Interaction

Range	Objects within 1.8 m at the centre of the view can be used.
Focus feedback	No crosshair. A focused object gets a faint pencil-line outline (like Sora sketching it) and Sora's right hand lifts slightly towards it. A soft paper tick sound plays the first time an object is focused.
Using	Short actions happen on press; continuous actions (dials, bellows, pouring) follow the mouse or stick while the key is held.
Reading documents	Picking up a document brings it close to the camera. A transcript in the chosen language can be shown beside it (on by default), so handwritten Khmer or French is always readable.
Cannot use	If an action is impossible, Sora's hand hesitates and pulls back; the sketchbook may gain a hint the second time.

04 The Satchel



- The game keeps running while the satchel is open; footsteps and breathing remain audible, so opening it near a threat is a risk.
- Item counts appear physically (several bottles, the number of matches when the box is opened). A small handwritten label appears only when an item is inspected.
- Combining fragments (Ep 1) shows them clicking together in Sora's hands.

05 The Sketchbook

Section (ribbon tab)	Contents
Map	Sora's map of the current area, drawn as she explores; the Cambodia map with blood marks; the seven night circles.
Now	Current objectives as small drawings with a few words (for example the three vigil duties).
Notes	Summaries of documents and recordings; puzzle clues copied by Sora (the betel drawing, the gramophone dial, the safe date).
People	Quick portraits of characters with a line about each, updated as the story changes.
Lore	Collected lore notes, with an empty outline for each one not yet found in the episode.

- New entries: a quiet pencil-scratch sound and a short shift of Sora's hand to her satchel. No pop-up.
- Page turning with `A`/`D` or the mouse; tabs selectable directly (`1`–`5` in the S5 prototype). While the book is open, `A`/`D` turn pages instead of strafing; `W`/`S` still walk.
- Text on pages is drawn large enough to read at 1080p: at least 28 px tall (S5 measured 28.6 px); the "large text" setting increases it by 30% (37 px), with the pages laid out again.

06 Communicating Without a HUD

6.1 Player state

State	How the player knows
Lamp oil	Glass gauge on the lamp (raise the lamp to read it clearly); the flame shrinks and sputters below 25%.
Matches left	Visible when the matchbox is opened in the satchel.
Noise	Footstep sounds by surface; Sora's breathing grows louder when hurrying.
Hidden	Sound muffles slightly; vignette deepens; heartbeat slows.
Threat nearby	Spatial sound of the entity; Sora's breathing and heartbeat quicken; slight vignette pulse.
Wet and cold (Ep 3)	Water-streak vignette at the screen edges; shivering breath; unsteady view; lamp flicker.
Shadow damage (Ep 5)	Screen darkens and desaturates; sound distorts; recovers slowly.
Taboo broken	A distinct low sound and a short entry in the sketchbook.

6.2 Progress

Event	How the player knows
Objective updated	New "Now" page drawing, with a pencil sound.
Checkpoint reached	A page-turn sound and the save indicator (6.3).
Being caught	Short scare, fade, a torn page, restart.
Episode complete	Summary page in the sketchbook: lore found, respect symbols, the night count.

6.3 Permitted on-screen elements

Element	Rule
Subtitles	Bottom centre, maximum two lines, optional speaker names and background.
Save indicator	A small lamp icon in the top-right corner while saving. Important on the web, so players don't close the tab mid-save.
Control hints	Shown the first time an action is needed, as pencil text that fades; never repeated once performed (can be re-enabled).
Accessibility aids	Interaction dot, sound captions and directional threat indicator, only when enabled.

07 Teaching the Controls

Beat	Action taught	How
P01	Look, move	Pencil hints fade in after 3 s if the player hasn't moved
P02	Interact	The illustration is the only focusable object at first
P03–P04	Pick up, satchel	The satchel opens automatically the first time it is collected
P05	Sketchbook	The ink-blot page appears; a hint shows `Q`
A1-01	Lamp, matches	Darkness at the carriage forces lighting the lamp
A1-05	Objectives	The three duties are drawn on the "Now" page
A2-06	Hiding, lamp off	The walker approaches slowly; a hint appears only if the player hasn't hidden within 4 s
A3-03	Crouch	The roamer's sound makes crouching useful; hint if not yet used

08 Menus

Menu	Items
Main menu	Continue · New game · Episodes · Enter save code · Settings · Credits
Pause	Resume · Restart from checkpoint · Settings · Copy save code · Main menu
Episodes	Episode cards; locked episodes show "Coming soon"; completed episodes show the night count and lore found
Episode end	Summary page · Copy save code for the next episode · Continue

Menus are HTML over the canvas, styled like Sora's paper, set in Ubuntu and Preah Vihear. The main menu background is a slow, live view of the funeral tent in the rain.

09 Settings and Accessibility

Category	Options
Graphics	Quality preset (Low, Medium, High, Ultra; chosen automatically at first launch) · dynamic resolution on/off · render scale · field of view (60–95°) · brightness calibration · film grain · chromatic aberration · head-bob · motion blur off by default
Audio	Master · ambience · effects · voice · music · headphone mode (sharper 3D positioning)
Language	Interface: English / Khmer · Subtitles: English / Khmer / off · Voice: Khmer
Subtitles	Size (small, medium, large) · background opacity · speaker names · sound captions (e.g. "[dragging footsteps, above]")
Controls	Mouse sensitivity · invert Y · rebind keys · crouch and hold-breath as toggle or hold · gamepad layout and vibration
Accessibility	Interaction dot · directional indicator for threat sounds · document transcripts · pause while satchel or sketchbook is open · reduced lightning flashes · large sketchbook text · story mode (slower, less perceptive spirits)

WHY THESE MATTER

The game relies heavily on sound and darkness. Sound captions, the threat indicator and brightness calibration make it playable for deaf and hard-of-hearing players and on poor screens without changing the experience for others.

10 Browser Behaviour

Situation	Behaviour
Mouse capture	Clicking the game requests pointer lock. Browsers always release it on `Esc`, so losing pointer lock opens the pause menu; this is why `Esc` cannot be rebound.
Audio start	Audio unlocks on the first click (the main menu's Start button), as browsers require.
Tab hidden or window unfocused	Pause the game and mute audio; resume to the pause menu, not straight into play.
Fullscreen	A button in the menu and settings; `F11` also works. The game also runs well windowed.
Closing the tab	If a save is in progress, the browser's "leave site?" warning is shown.
Unsupported device	Without WebGPU, with a software renderer (hardware acceleration off), or on a phone or tablet (including iPad), show the requirements page (minimum and recommended hardware, supported browsers, and what to try) instead of a broken page. Laptops with integrated graphics are supported and start on Low.
Keyboard layouts	Bindings use physical key positions so they work on non-QWERTY layouts.
Trackpad	Laptops are supported, so the game plays with a trackpad: pointer lock uses raw (unaccelerated) movement where the browser allows it, and crouch can be set to toggle instead of hold.